

Figure 3: Simple and curved paths

to create a line, we place two points using the *paths* tool. Select the *paths* tool from the tool box and click on the worksheet. Move the mouse away from the first vanishing point in order to provide the line a second vanishing point. Click again to create the second point. You can place multiple points to make quadrilaterals and other useful shapes.

- **Curved path:** It's easy: first create a simple path. Then, with the *paths* tool still selected, grab (left-click) the line anywhere between the two points and drag it off the 'straight line' to curve the path. Once you have dragged the path from its initial position, you will notice that the end points grow dotted lines with a small square at the ends. These are modifiers, which help us fine tune the curve and its ends. We will be using this method a lot in this tutorial. Refer to Figure 3 for an idea of what a simple path and a curved path look like.

Tip: To join the starting and ending points of a path: While the end point is still selected, hold the CTRL key and then select the starting point (or any other point you desire to join).

Now let's get started with shaping up the wallpaper. We create every new shape in a new transparent layer.

Step 8 Create a new transparent layer, grab the *paths* tool and create a curved path, as shown in Figure 4. To do this, create a starting line at the upper boundary of the image, and drag the centre of the path down to curve it. Use the modifiers to adjust it to look exactly like what's shown in Part 1 of Figure 4. Once you're done, press *Enter* to convert the path to a selection.

Step 9 *Invert the selection (Select → Invert).* Now grab the *Airbrush* from the tool box and select the Circle Fuzzy (19) brush with the FG colour set to black. Apply the brush gently at the boundaries, so that it resembles the shadow of the shape we created. Make the shadow more pronounced at the corners and sides, while keeping it to a bare minimum at the centre of the shape.

Step 10 Set the Layer mode to *Overlay*. Provide more shadow if you like, but don't overdo it! Discard the active selection by pressing *Ctrl+Shift+A*.

Step 11 Create a new layer. Now head to the *Paths* tab

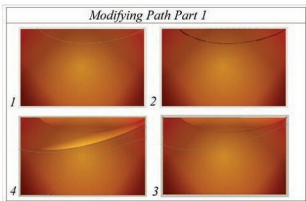


Figure 4: Modifying paths, Part 1

(this dockable dialogue box is also called the *Path History* tab, as mentioned in a previous article in this series). There, right-click the path that you have created, and choose *Path to Selection*. Grab the *Blend* tool. With FG set to *white*, and blend mode set to *FG to Transparent*, apply a small blend from the top of the selection to the bottom, just for a nice effect. Set the layer mode to *Overlay*. That's the first shape we intend to create; there are still three to go. If you've got this part down all right, the rest will be quite easy.

Step 12 Create a new layer. Using the *paths* tool, create a curved path, as shown in Part 3 of Figure 4. Convert the path to a selection by pressing *Enter*, and apply the same airbrush shadow using the procedure shown in Step 9 above. Once done, set the layer mode to *Overlay*. Discard the active selection by pressing *Ctrl+Shift+A*.

Step 13 Now make the selection active for the newly created path, via the *Paths* tab, as mentioned in Step 11. Once done, shrink the selection by 5 via *Select → Shrink*. Create a new layer and apply a gradient as shown, with the same settings used above. Set the layer mode to *Overlay*. That completes the second shape of the wallpaper.

Step 14 The third shape, located at the centre of the wallpaper, is the star attraction; so we will add more depth and detail to it—entailing a slightly different approach from the previous two.

Create a new transparent layer, and with the *paths* tool, mark a selection as shown in Figure 5. With the new layer selected, apply a gradient (with the same settings as above) from right to left, inside the selection. Make sure the path created has formed an active selection. Set the layer mode to *Overlay*.

Step 15 Create a new layer. Invert the selection via *Select → Invert*. Grab the *Airbrush* and, with *black* as the FG colour, apply the shadow all over the upper and lower part of the middle curve. As usual, keep the shadow to the minimum in the middle portion. Discard the active selection by pressing *Ctrl+Shift+A*.